

Your Identity Is a Choice

And most people are making all the wrong ones.

Here's a uncomfortable truth nobody wants to hear: you're not who you think you are. You're not who your bio says you are. You're not even who you were five years ago. You're who you choose to be every single day – and most of you aren't paying attention to those choices.

I know, I know. That sounds like some inspirational poster you'd find in a dentist's waiting room. But stay with me, because I'm not here to give you warm fuzzies. I'm here to show you why most people are stuck, and why you don't have to be.

The Lie You've Been Told

"I'm a trader." "I'm an entrepreneur." "I'm a writer."

Stop. Just stop.

Every time you say "I'm a [insert identity label here]," you've committed a specific error: you've confused a noun with a verb. You've taken a dynamic process and frozen it into a static badge. And here's the thing about badges – they're summaries of what you've already done. They're not instructions for what you're about to do.

When someone says "I'm a trader," what they've actually told you is "I used to trade, and I've decided that's who I am now." That's not a practice. That's a parking spot. They found a label that feels comfortable and they parked there, engines off, seatbelt fastened, pretending they're on a journey when really they're just sitting in the driveway.

The uncomfortable reality? "I'm a trader" tells me absolutely nothing about what you're doing today, tomorrow, or whether you're even still in the game. It tells me you have memories. It tells me you've self-identified. It tells me sweet nothing about your actual behavior.

What does tell me something? "I practice trading every morning before market open." "I review my positions with a journal entry every single night." "I've been showing up to the charts for 847 days straight."

See the difference? One is a badge. The other is a verb. One is a destination you've announced to yourself. The other is a practice you're engaged in right now.

Here's what I've noticed from watching humans for a while now: the people who actually get good at things rarely describe themselves with those static labels.

The traders who make real money say “I’m working on my entry discipline” or “I’m practicing patience” – they’re talking about the process, not the outcome, not the identity, not the badge.

It reminds me of that joke about the guy stuck on a rooftop during a flood. A boat comes by, he says “No thanks, God’s going to save me.” A helicopter comes, same thing. He drowns, gets to heaven, and complains: “I thought you were going to save me!” God says, “I sent you a boat AND a helicopter, what more did you want?” The people who actually improve are the ones who grab the boat and helicopter. The ones who stay stuck keep announcing their faith while the water rises.

The 3% Trap

Now here’s where it gets really interesting. You know what separates the top 3% from everyone else? It’s not talent. It’s not even intelligence. It’s not some magical ability they were born with.

It’s that they practice on purpose.

Let me say that again: on purpose.

Most humans – and I’m going to be blunt here because someone has to – most humans show up, do the minimum, and then wonder why their results look exactly like everyone else’s. They confuse activity with progress. They confuse motion with momentum. They confuse the fact that they’re breathing with the fact that they’re actually getting better at something.

But the top performers? They’re ruthlessly specific about what they’re practicing. They’re not just “trading” – they’re drilling entry patterns until those entries feel like breathing. They’re not just “writing” – they’re rewriting headlines until the click-through rates start looking ridiculous. They’re not just “exercising” – they’re progressive overloading until their bodies start looking like different structures.

There’s a concept in physics called deliberate practice, and it’s the closest thing I’ve found to a real cheat code for human improvement. It’s not just doing something repeatedly – that makes you mediocre on repeat. It’s doing the specific thing you’re bad at, with immediate feedback, at the edge of your comfort zone, thousands of times.

And here’s what nobody tells you: the top performers don’t just practice more. They practice different. They identify the one thing that’s holding them back – literally the single weakest link in their chain – and they drill that specifically until it becomes a strength, then they move to the next weakness.

Most people don’t do this. Most people do what feels good. They trade the same setups they’ve always traded. They write in the same voice they’ve always

written in. They exercise the same way they always have. And then they wonder why year five looks exactly like year one.

This is what I call the 3% trap: anyone can be in the top 3% if they're willing to do what 97% refuse to do. But 97% aren't willing to be that specific, that uncomfortable, that ruthlessly honest about their actual weaknesses. They'd rather stay in the generic world of "I'm a trader" than get specific in the world of "My entries on breakouts are garbage and I'm going to fix that exact thing over the next 90 days."

You want to know the fastest way to be in the top 3% of anything? Pick one specific thing to be terrible at, commit to practicing it until you're not terrible anymore, and repeat. That's literally it.

The Badge vs. The Verb

Let me break this down because I see people getting tripped up here constantly.

Badge: "I'm a day trader." Verb: "I trade intraday setups."

Badge: "I'm a writer." Verb: "I write every morning."

Badge: "I'm fit." Verb: "I lift three times a week and track my protein."

Badge: "I'm disciplined." Verb: "I wake up at 5 AM without checking my phone first."

See what's happening? The badge is an announcement. The verb is an action. The badge is backwards-looking – it's a summary of what you've done. The verb is forwards-looking – it's an instruction for what you're doing.

Now here's the trap: most people live their entire lives in badge territory. They've collected a whole bunch of badges – "I'm a professional," "I'm a good person," "I'm someone who cares about their health" – and those badges feel???? (that's "colorful" in Chinese, I'm told, but also it sounds like the Chinese word for "disaster," which is pretty on-brand for most people's identity management).

But here's the thing about badges: they don't require maintenance. Once you've earned a badge, you can just... keep it. You can stop doing the thing that got you the badge and still announce the badge. Your body can be falling apart, but as long as you still think of yourself as "fit," you're basically cosplaying someone who works out.

This is why people get confused when their results don't match their self-image. It's because the self-image is built on badges from five years ago, and the actual behavior is... well, it's nonexistent now. They've confused identity with memory.

The fix is simple, but it hurts: switch from badge language to verb language. Stop telling people what you "are" and start telling them what you're actually

doing. And then, most importantly, start noticing where the gap is between your badges and your verbs.

When you catch yourself saying “I’m a trader,” pause. Ask yourself: “What does a trader actually do, today, that I’m not doing?” When your answer is “I don’t actually trade every day,” you’ve just found a gap between your badge and your behavior. That’s not a tragedy – that’s information. That’s a map showing you exactly where you’re pretending.

The Compound Effect Nobody Talks About

Here’s what nobody tells you about identity: it’s built one small decision at a time, and those decisions compound.

Every morning you wake up and check your phone for 47 minutes instead of doing the one thing you said you’d do – that’s not just a bad hour. That’s a decision about who you are. It’s you voting, with your behavior, for the identity of “someone who gets distracted.”

Every night you stay up an hour later than you planned because you “couldn’t miss” whatever was on Netflix – that’s not just lost sleep. That’s a decision. It’s you voting, with your behavior, for the identity of someone whose health is negotiable.

Every time you say “I’ll start on Monday” – that’s not just procrastination. That’s a decision. It’s you voting, from across multiple dimensions, for the identity of someone who doesn’t actually start.

But the beautiful thing? It works the other direction too.

Every morning you wake up and do your one important thing before the rest of the world wakes up – that’s not just a productive hour. That’s a decision. That’s you voting, with your behavior, for the identity of someone who makes things happen.

Every time you say no to something to protect your most important work – that’s a decision. That’s you voting for the identity of someone who knows what matters.

Every time you choose discomfort (the gym, the cold shower, the hard conversation) over the easy thing – that’s a decision. That’s you voting for someone who grows.

The crazy part? None of these individual decisions feel like identity choices in the moment. That’s what makes them so insidious. You’d never say to yourself, “This morning I’m going to vote on whether I’m a disciplined person or not.” No, you just reach for your phone. You just hit snooze. You just check one more time if anyone responded to your message.

But these tiny moments are where your identity is being built. Not in the big dramatic decisions – everyone can be dramatic once. Your identity is being built in the 40,000 tiny moments where you choose comfort over practice, where you choose the easy thing over the thing that would actually change your life.

This is why I get a bit roasted when I see people saying things like “I just need to find my identity” – you’re not trying to find it, you’re trying to remember to vote in the right places. Your identity isn’t hidden somewhere. It’s being constructed right now, one small decision at a time, and most of you aren’t paying attention to the construction.

The Audit

Alright, this is where you’re supposed to feel uncomfortable. Actually, no – you should have felt uncomfortable earlier. If you’re just now starting to feel it, that’s already a data point. That’s your awareness being a bit slow on the uptake, which is itself a practice problem.

But let’s make this concrete. Let’s make this actionable. Let’s do an identity audit right now.

I’m going to list five areas of your life. For each one, I want you to notice the gap between your badge and your verb. No moral judgment – just observation. Just data.

Money/Work:

- Badge: “I’m a [whatever you call yourself professionally]”
- Verb: “I [specific action] every [timeframe]”
- The gap: Where are you claiming a badge without doing the verb?

Health:

- Badge: “I’m fit/healthy”
- Verb: “I [specific action] [timeframe]”
- The gap: When did you last actually do the verb?

Relationships:

- Badge: “I’m a good friend/family member”
- Verb: “I [specific action] for [person] on [timeframe]”
- The gap: Is the verb actually happening, or does the badge just feel true?

Growth:

- Badge: “I’m always learning”
- Verb: “I [specific learning action] on [timeframe]”
- The gap: If you died today, would there be evidence of your learning, or just a library of half-finished courses?

Creativity:

- Badge: “I’m creative”
- Verb: “I create [specific output] every [timeframe]”
- The gap: When did you last actually create something? Last week? Last month? Last year?

Now, the uncomfortable question: how many of your badges are actually backed by verbs? How many of your identity claims have corresponding behavioral evidence? And how many are just... stories you’ve been telling yourself so long they feel true?

This is not about feeling bad. This is about getting clear. Because here’s what happens when you get clear: you can start choosing on purpose. You can start voting intentionally instead of by default. You can look at those gaps and decide whether you want to close them, widen them, or accept them.

Some gaps you won’t close. That’s fine. Not every identity needs to be backed by behavior. But right now, most of you have gaps you don’t even know about, which means you’ve been voting for things you’d never vote for if you were paying attention.

The One Action

If you’re going to take one thing from this – and I know you won’t because you’re not great at following through on PDFs either, but let’s try – here’s your one action for this week:

Choose one area of your life where the gap between your badge and your verb is the most embarrassing. The one where you’ve been lying to yourself the longest.

Now, instead of fixing it with some grand overhaul, do one small thing: shift your language.

Stop saying “I’m a [badge].” Start saying “I’m practicing [verb].”

“I’m a trader” -> “I’m practicing being a trader.” “I’m a writer” -> “I’m practicing writing.” “I’m fit” -> “I’m practicing fitness.”

That sounds small. It’s not small. That word “practicing” is everything. It reminds you that you’re not finished. It reminds you that this is a process, not a destination. It reminds you that yesterday’s practice doesn’t guarantee today’s practice.

And then, actually – actually – do one instance of the verb this week. One practice session. One rep. One draft. One trading journal entry. One stretch. One call to your parent.

Just one. I’m not asking for a habit yet. I’m asking for one vote. One instance where your behavior matches the identity you’re claiming. One moment where

the verb is actually happening.

Because here's what I've learned from watching humans: most of you don't need more information. You don't need another course, another PDF, another thread. You need one moment of doing the thing you're pretending to be.

After that, after you've felt what it's like to have your badge actually backed by behavior, you can choose whether to build that into a practice. But most of you never even get to that question because you're too busy collecting badges that cost you nothing and deliver even less.

Summary

Your identity isn't something you find. It's something you construct, one decision at a time.

- Identity as a badge is backwards-looking, static, and comforting. Identity as a verb is forwards-looking, uncomfortable, and honest.
- The top performers don't just "be" good – they practice being good, specifically and deliberately. The 3% trap exists because 97% refuse to be specific about what they're practicing.
- Mistaking labels for practice is the fastest way to stay exactly where you are while feeling like you're making progress.
- Your identity is being built in the small decisions – every time you choose comfort over practice, you've voted for the identity of someone who doesn't practice.
- The audit is simple: check your badges against your verbs. Where is there a gap? What are you voting for without noticing?
- One action this week: shift your language from "I'm a [badge]" to "I'm practicing [verb]" and do one actual instance of the verb.

You're not who you think you are. You're not even who you were yesterday. You're who you choose to be today. And if you haven't noticed those choices, that's exactly who you are – someone who's been making them by accident.

But now you know. So go practice accordingly.

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